

S02-02 - Eyes in the Brush

Player read-aloud

A branch cracks somewhere beyond the road. For half a breath, the forest watches back.

Scene summary

Hidden watchers prepare to spring the trap unless the PCs spot them first.

Visible choices

- Instinct roll
- Draw weapons
- Call out
- Use carriage as cover

Player questions

- What detail in Eyes in the Brush tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

Raw source

- Id: S02-02
- Act: Act Two
- Title: Eyes in the Brush
- Beats: Clue discovery Roll/check Consequence
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png
- Short: Hidden watchers prepare to spring the trap unless the PCs spot them first.
- Long: This is the hinge between mystery and battle. If players noticed signs, reward them with readiness.
- Read: A branch cracks somewhere beyond the road. For half a breath, the forest watches back.
- Gm: If Strixwolf Mercy applies, her distant warning cry can grant advantage here.
- Entities: Bramble Union Bramble Union Ambusher Bramble Union Claimrunner Disposition / Resolution Track Varian Soto Strixwolf Mother Escort Carriage Garrick Reed Short Rest Hidden Sealed Keystone Crate
- Choices: Instinct roll Draw weapons Call out Use carriage as cover
- Prompt: Tense forest road: party realizes hidden figures watching from thorny undergrowth; carriage and sealed crate vulnerable; bramblefolk silhouettes and glints of blades; no strixwolf, no undead.
- Source Entities: Bramble Union Bramble Union Ambusher Bramble Union Claimrunner Strixwolf Mercy Track
- Beat Codes: clue-discovery roll-check consequence
- Slug: S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush
- Act Title: Cargo Reclaimers

- Arc Role: External opposition and morally complicated conflict
- Caption: Eyes in the brush turn investigation into an impending tactical decision.
- Image Alt: Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Image Prompt Used: Tense forest road: party realizes hidden figures watching from thorny undergrowth; carriage and sealed crate vulnerable; bramblefolk silhouettes and glints of blades; no strixwolf, no undead. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. Do not include undead, skeletons, wraiths, Open Vale, the Custodian, or the Hanging Office. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: This is the hinge between mystery and battle. If players noticed signs, reward them with readiness. Run this scene as external opposition and morally complicated conflict: Eyes in the brush turn investigation into an impending tactical decision. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: A branch cracks somewhere beyond the road. For half a breath, the forest watches back.
- Gm Notes: If Strixwolf Mercy applies, her distant warning cry can grant advantage here. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- Sensory Details: a twig snapping too politely bird calls repeating like signals green thread caught waist-high
- Body Language: Varian's ears angle before his hand moves Garrick shifts between carriage and brush
- Sample Dialogue: Varian Soto Three watchers. Maybe four if the quiet one is better than me.
- Checks: Instinct Spot the scout net before it closes. Standard Avoid surprise or identify a negotiation angle. 15 Cleanly resolve: Spot the scout net before it closes. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Eyes in the Brush. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.
- Choices Consequences: Call out the watchers Opens a tense parley before violence. Negotiation track possible. Set counter-ambush Better tactical position. Bramble casualties more likely.
- Clues: Signal knots An ambush is near. They planned for cargo, not slaughter. The watchers coordinate by tied bramble markers.
- Loot: Signal knot Hidden boot track
- Payoff Flags: Bramble Union Resolution Track Strixwolf Mercy Track
- Filters: act-two bramble-union-resolution-track cargo-reclaimers choice clue-discovery consequence gm-only rollcheck strixwolf-mercy-track clue faction manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned
- Index: 6

- Player Questions: What detail in Eyes in the Brush tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in Eyes in the Brush that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- Fear Spends: Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclamer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Conditional Notes: S02-02 strixwolf_outcome=calmed|helped Payoff: A distant strixwolf hoot gives the party a heartbeat of warning. Grant advantage on the Instinct roll or lower the difficulty by one step. S02-02 strixwolf_outcome=killed Consequence: The noise and blood draw the Bramble Union forward faster. The ambush is harder to spot, or the Claimrunner begins closer to the carriage.
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclamer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate. Knowledge: recognize corporate-issue gear. ACT2 Act 2: Bramble ambush 90 0:55 to 1:30 1:30 first combat and possible interrogation Abstract the fight via a Group Action roll; keep one captured reclamer for the interrogation seed.
- Mechanics: The party is in Act Two pressure: Hidden watchers prepare to spring the trap unless the PCs spot them first. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s02-02-spot-watchers-before-the-ambush S02-02 Spot watchers before the ambush Spot watchers before the ambush Instinct Finesse Instinct Finesse 14 Instinct senses eyes; Finesse

moves without giving away the scan. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party may start the ambush surrounded...

- Roll Cards: s02-02-spot-watchers-before-the-ambush S02-02 Spot watchers before the ambush Spot watchers before the ambush Instinct Finesse Instinct Finesse 14 Instinct senses eyes; Finesse moves without giving away the scan. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time...
- Conditions Hazards: Hidden Restrained
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Eyes in the Brush asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Finesse, Instinct, Knowledge. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Factionids: bramble-union
- World Connection Prompts: S02-02-bramble-union-world-connection bramble-union The Bramble Union You have been desperate enough to do something you are not proud of. What was it, and would you do it again to eat?
- Clueids: bramble-claim-marker bramble-are-criminals-noticetm
- Clue Ids: bramble-claim-marker bramble-are-criminals-noticetm
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